an important neighbour: Bangladesh. This 271-kilometre borderline west of the Arakan Yoma — one of the two mountain ranges that separates the western coastal strip of Myanmar from the central plains — links with River Naaf at the south for 64 kilometres as it extends into the Bay of Bengal. The international boundary runs along the mid-stream of the river, which flows through the townships of Teknaf on the Bangladesh side, and Maungdaw of Myanmar on the other.

The presence of major cities like Cox's Bazar (also Saint Martin's Island, a naval base and a popular tourist spot opposite Myanmar's west coast) for Bangladesh, and Sittwe (previously known as Akyab) hosting the biggest seaport as well as air and naval bases for Myanmar, adds significance to this border region. While urbanization and trade activities around Cox's Bazar and Teknaf have ensured a steady growth for this bordering region in Bangladesh, on the Myanmar side the Rakhine State has largely fallen behind in development.

Post-independence relations between Myanmar and Bangladesh stagnated. Although Myanmar was one of the first few countries to recognize Bangladesh's independence in 1972, only four Bangladeshi heads of government have made state-level visits to Myanmar (the latest in December 2011 when Bangladesh's Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina visited Naypyitaw), with no visits for twenty-three years between 1988 and 2011. Similarly, on the Myanmar side, state-level visits took place in 1974, 1979, 1980, and 2002 — also four in total, and with a similar period of abstention (twenty-two years, between 1980 and 2002). The diplomatic dexterity that saw through successful negotiations in 1978–79 between two generals (Ziaur Rahman for Bangladesh and Ne Win for Burma) to affect a full repatriation of the Rohingya people who flocked to Bangladesh due to military oppression in Arakan somehow lost its impetus along the way (Haque 1993, pp. 129–48).

The countries have not fared better on the trade and business front either. Till 2015, neither country featured in the list of the other's top five export or import destinations (WTO 2015). While Bangladesh has it in her interest to persuade Myanmar to allow cross-border transit to China (Amin 2014), Myanmar, by contrast, has emerged as Bangladesh's major competitor, and has used its geostrategic location to offer transit facilities to India, China, and other Southeast Asian countries. It has consistently opposed Bangladesh's proposal for a southern route of the Asian Highway, citing reasons of national security (Banik 2015).